

# Lecture 3: Political Regimes (FK)

Political Science — Master Notes · by Jakob V. Stangel

**Required reading:** OD ch. 3 (*States, Citizens, and Regimes*)

**Theme of the lecture (Filip Kiil):** ch. 2 asked *what a state is*; ch. 3 asks *what kind of government rules it* — the **regime** — and sorts regimes by the **ideology** that answers **who may rule and what rights citizens get**.

**Lecture frame (FK) — the State–Regime–Citizen(–Ideology) nexus**

**Core:** four linked concepts; the **regime** sits between the permanent **state** and the current **government**, and is classified by its **ideology**.

- **State** — the ongoing administrative apparatus (ch. 2); most enduring.
- **Regime** — the formal + **informal** institutions defining the *type* of government; more enduring than governments, less than the state. (US: 46 administrations, one democratic regime since 1789; Nigeria: 8 regimes.)
- **Citizen** — a member of the political community with **rights + duties** (vs a *subject*, who has only duties/obedience).
- **Ideology** — defines the **state–citizen relationship** and is how we classify regimes — but regimes often **diverge** from their ideology (informal institutions dominate, especially in weak states).

**The V-Dem / "Regimes of the World" ladder** (Lührmann, Tannenberg & Lindberg 2018) — the modern measure the lecture uses:

| Regime                     | Multi-party elections? | Free & fair?                                | Rights + checks on the executive?           |
|----------------------------|------------------------|---------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| <b>Closed autocracy</b>    | No                     | —                                           | No                                          |
| <b>Electoral autocracy</b> | Yes                    | <b>No</b> (restrictions undermine fairness) | No                                          |
| <b>Electoral democracy</b> | Yes                    | <b>Yes</b>                                  | Partial                                     |
| <b>Liberal democracy</b>   | Yes                    | Yes                                         | <b>Yes</b> (rights, legal equality, checks) |

**Explaining regime *change*** (the same **Interests / Beliefs / Structures** lens from Lecture 1):

| Lens              | How it explains change                                                                                                         |
|-------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Interests</b>  | Elites expand/restrict democracy to maximise power (democratise post-1990 for aid; <b>backslide</b> when power is threatened). |
| <b>Beliefs</b>    | Democratic ideals spread in 19th–20th c.; fascism/communism caused reversals; recent <b>populism</b> erodes liberal values.    |
| <b>Structures</b> | Industrialisation enabled democratisation; Cold War blocs sustained autocracy; globalisation/inequality now strain democracy.  |

## OD Ch. 3 — States, Citizens, and Regimes

**Book:** Orvis & Drogus, *Introducing Comparative Politics*, 5th ed., ch. 3.

### Chapter résumé

Examines the **state↔people** relationship as embodied in different **regimes** — the formal + informal institutions defining a *type* of government. It traces the rise of the "**citizen**" (vs "subject") and of **civil society**, presents **T.H. Marshall's** three rights of citizenship (civil, political, social), then gives the chapter's core: a **taxonomy of regime types classified by ideology** — liberal democracy, communism, fascism, modernizing authoritarianism, personalist, electoral authoritarianism, theocracy. A recurring thread: **no regime works exactly as its ideology claims** — informal institutions often matter more.

★ **The heart of the chapter:** a **regime** = the formal + informal institutions defining a \*type\* of government, classified by its **ideology**. The single axis that orders them all: **how much power goes to citizens vs. the state**. **Liberal democracy** (limited state, broad rights) is the benchmark; every other regime tilts power toward the state and restricts full citizenship to a select group.

**The red thread.** Read the whole chapter as answers to **one question** — *how is power shared between citizens and the state?* Liberal democracy shares it widely (limited government + Marshall's rights); communism, fascism, modernizing & electoral authoritarianism, and theocracy concentrate it (in the party / a leader / a developing elite / God), restricting full citizenship to the working class / loyal nationals / the developers / the faithful. For **every** regime type ask: **who has power, and what rights do citizens get?**

### Key concepts / "modes" to use

- **State vs regime vs government** — continuous apparatus / *type* of government / current occupants.
- **Citizen vs subject** — rights + duties vs duties only.
- **Marshall's three rights** — **civil • political • social** (the yardstick for "full" citizenship).
- **Ideology-based regime taxonomy** — the seven types (below).
- **Dahl's 8 guarantees** — the working definition of liberal democracy.

- **Formal vs informal institutions** — informal rules (patronage, factions) often explain how a regime *really* works.

## Section-by-section main points

### | Citizens & civil society

**Core:** modern politics invented the **citizen** (rights + duties) out of the **subject** (obedience only) — and full citizenship needs all three of **Marshall's rights**.

- **Citizen vs subject:** 200–300 years ago Europeans were **subjects** of absolutist monarchs (no mechanism to protect "rights"); citizenship arose as sovereignty moved from the monarch to "**the people**" (after the French Revolution people addressed each other as "*citizen*").
- **Marshall (1963) — three rights:** **civil** (individual freedom, fair treatment) · **political** (participation, vote) · **social** (welfare, socioeconomic equality). Full citizenship needs *enough* social equality to make civil/political equality real. **Virtually no country fully provides all three.**
- **Civil society** — organised, nongovernmental, nonviolent activity by groups larger than families/firms; impossible under absolutism, enabled by religious pluralism + capitalism.
- **Popular sovereignty** — even dictators claim to rule *on behalf of* the people (theocracy claims God willed the exception). Emerging **postnational** citizenship (EU, ICC) — but core rights still sit in the **nation-state**.

### | Regimes, ideologies & citizens

**Core:** regimes are classified by **ideology**, but never match it perfectly — **informal institutions** often dominate (especially in weak states).

- **Liberal democracy** is the **benchmark all regimes respond to: ~90% of the world's constitutions** — including authoritarian ones — mention "democracy" (Elkins et al. 2014).

### | The regime taxonomy — *memorise this (the exam core)*

**Core:** seven regime types, each defined by an ideology answering **who has power** and **what citizens get**.

| Regime                              | Key idea                                                                                | Who has power                                      |
|-------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Liberal democracy</b>            | Individuals free with natural rights; govt must preserve <b>life, liberty, property</b> | The <b>legislature</b> (elected, removable)        |
| <b>Communism</b>                    | <u>Historical materialism</u> → proletarian revolution → classless, stateless society   | <b>Vanguard party</b> now; the proletariat "later" |
| <b>Fascism</b>                      | Organic society; the <b>state creates the nation</b> ; corporatism                      | A <b>supreme leader</b>                            |
| <b>Modernizing authoritarianism</b> | <i>Development</i> needs unity, so democracy must wait                                  | A <b>modern (educated) elite</b>                   |
| <b>Personalist regime</b>           | Claims to modernise but is really <b>neopatrimonial</b>                                 | An <b>individual ruler</b>                         |
| <b>Electoral authoritarianism</b>   | Blends democratic + authoritarian legitimacy                                            | The <b>ruling party</b> (via rigged elections)     |
| <b>Theocracy</b>                    | Rule by <b>divine</b> authority (Islamism → sharia)                                     | <b>God</b> (via the clergy) — not the people       |

## Liberal democracy

**Core:** liberal democracy = democracy (rule by the people) + liberalism (individual rights) — a *limited* state that protects rights and holds free, competitive elections.

- **Roots:** liberalism arose in the 16th–17th-c. religious wars; social contract theory (Hobbes, Locke, Montesquieu, Rousseau). **Locke:** government is legitimate only if it preserves **life, liberty, property** (Jefferson → "pursuit of happiness"). Democracy was added later; early liberals limited citizenship to **male property owners** — expanded over the 19th–20th c.
- **Dahl's 8 guarantees** (the working definition): freedom of **association** · **expression** · right to **vote** · broad **office eligibility** · leaders' right to **compete** · alternative **information** · **free & fair elections** · institutions that make policy **depend on votes**.
- **Varieties of democracy:** **liberal** (political rights — UK) · **social democracy** (adds economic regulation + social rights — Sweden; a variant *within* liberal democracy) · **participatory** (direct involvement beyond voting — Switzerland).

## Communism

**Core:** Marx's historical materialism — economic forces drive history — predicts a proletarian revolution ending in a classless, stateless utopia; in practice it produced the totalitarian state.

- **Feudalism → capitalism → socialism → communism.** Liberal democracy is a "shell" for capitalism; liberal rights = "*equal rights for unequal people*."
- **Stages:** **socialism** = collective ownership + dictatorship of the proletariat (a *class* dictatorship) → eventually stateless, classless **communism** (human nature itself changes).
- **Critique:** any theory promising utopia tends toward the totalitarian state (Russia/Stalin case).

## Fascism

**Core:** antiliberal *and* anticommunist — the state creates and embodies the nation; the individual exists only for the state; citizens have **duties, not rights**.

- **Organic** conception of society; a **supreme leader** embodies the nation. **Corporatism:** one state-controlled organisation per sector (one union, one business association). Rejects rationality/materialism → glorifies struggle & war → **totalitarian** (Nazi Germany case).

## Modernizing authoritarianism

**Core:** legitimacy through **development, not rights** — a **modern elite** must guide progress, and democracy would only interfere.

- **Technocratic legitimacy** rooted in **modernization theory** (postcolonial states must follow the West's path). **Four institutional forms:** one-party (civilian; postcolonial Africa/Asia — Tanzania) · **military** (coup — Brazil) · **bureaucratic-authoritarian** · **personalist**.

## Personalist regimes

**Core:** in the **weakest states**, one leader captures everything — even the party/military that raised him — via **neopatrimonial** patron–client loyalty rather than institutions.

- Weak, unstable, unpredictable; rule of law inconsistent. Most common in Africa (Mobutu, Marcos, Abacha/Nigeria).

## Electoral authoritarianism (hybrid)

**Core:** a **hybrid** — real opposition and elections *exist*, but the ruling party **manipulates the rules** so it never actually loses; it **proclaims itself democratic**.

- Blends liberal-democratic (elections) + modernizing-authoritarian (limits for "stability/development") legitimacy. Spread after the Cold War because open authoritarianism lost international legitimacy (Mexico/PRI case).

## Theocracy

**Core:** rule by religious authorities on behalf of God — so ultimate sovereignty is **Allah's, not the people's**.

- **Islamism** (a 19th–20th-c. reaction to Western imperialism, *not* traditional): sharia should be the basis of government. Key terms: **sharia** (law) · **ijtihad** (individual interpretation) vs **taqlid** (blind acceptance) · **shura** (consultation — the opening for quasi-democracy) · **umma** (community) · **jihad** (three kinds: inner struggle [most important] → righting injustice → armed defence [least]). Iran is the world's **only true theocracy** (Iran case).

## Cases & examples

Why these cases are here — **circle them back**. Each country is a **worked example of one regime type**; read every case for (1) which type · (2) who has power · (3) what rights citizens get. The table

maps case → type; the write-ups tell the story.

| Case                    | Regime type                               | Who has power                  | Freedom House |
|-------------------------|-------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|---------------|
| <u>UK</u>               | <u>Liberal democracy</u>                  | Parliament (sovereign)         | Free          |
| <u>Russia/USSR</u>      | Communism → (now electoral authoritarian) | <u>Vanguard party</u> / Stalin | Not Free      |
| <u>Germany (Nazi)</u>   | Fascism                                   | A supreme leader               | (Free today)  |
| <u>Brazil</u>           | Modernizing authoritarian (military)      | Technocratic military elite    | Free (today)  |
| <u>Nigeria (Abacha)</u> | Personalist                               | One ruler (neopatrimonial)     | Partly Free   |
| <u>Mexico (PRI)</u>     | Electoral authoritarian                   | The ruling party               | Partly Free   |
| <u>Iran</u>             | Theocracy                                 | God (via the clergy)           | Not Free      |
| <u>Tanzania</u>         | Modernizing authoritarian (one-party)     | A single party                 | —             |

- **United Kingdom — "cradle of democracy."** Liberal democracy evolved **gradually**, with **no single written constitution** and no revolutionary break from monarchy: **Magna Carta (1215) → Glorious Revolution (1688) → Bill of Rights (1689)**; the franchise expanded only under pressure (1832 middle class ~7%; women's suffrage 1918); recent **devolution (1997)**, a standalone **Supreme Court (2005)**. → *The first liberal democracy; power rests on parliamentary sovereignty (a powerful informal institution) + the slow build-up of all three Marshall rights.*
- **Russia/USSR — the first "communist" regime.** Revolution came in the "wrong country" (agrarian, not advanced-capitalist). **Lenin** added the vanguard party and led the **October Revolution 1917**; **Stalin** built a totalitarian state (rapid industrialisation, **2–20 million deaths**); **Gorbachev's** reforms → collapse **Dec 1991** into 15 states. → *Communism in practice = the totalitarian state; the regime diverged wildly from Marx's theory (Marx → Lenin → Stalin).*
- **Germany — the rise of the Nazis (fascism).** Hitler was **elected, not a coup** — the Nazis won **37% (1932)** amid depression; the **Reichstag fire (1933)** → Enabling Act → dictatorship; unions replaced by a party-controlled front (corporatism); Nazism fused fascism with **racism** → the **Holocaust (~6m Jews)**. → *Fascism + totalitarian state; its horror delegitimised fascism globally, though neofascism persists (Le Pen's National Front — 2nd in France's 2002 presidential race).*
- **Brazil — a military modernizing-authoritarian regime (1964–85).** A US-backed coup installed a **technocratic military** elite that staked legitimacy on **development + anticommunism** (National Security Doctrine); state-led industry produced the "**Brazilian Miracle**" (1967–73) but rising inequality. When growth stalled, unions + the Church revived civil society → **democracy restored 1985**. → *Modernizing authoritarianism in military form — legitimacy = development, so no growth = no legitimacy.*
- **Nigeria — Abacha's personalist regime (1993–98).** After the military annulled the **1993 election**, **General Abacha** seized power, gutted the courts, jailed/killed opponents (hanged poet **Ken Saro-Wiwa**), and **looted ~\$3 billion** — ruling by **neopatrimonial** oil patronage. His **sudden death**

(1998) ended it; wary officers delivered the **democracy in place since 1999**. → *Personalist regime — a weak state's institutions crumble around one man.*

- **Mexico — the PRI (electoral authoritarianism)**. The PRI ruled ~71 years via regular *but rigged* elections — a **democratic veneer** over **clientelism, corporatism and fraud** (Tlatelolco Massacre 1968), with power rotated among factions and presidents limited to one **sexenio**. Erosion (contested 1988) → **Vicente Fox (PAN) broke the monopoly in 2000**. → *The classic hybrid regime — informal institutions (clientelism, fraud) dominate the formal democratic shell.*
- **Iran — the Islamic Republic (theocracy)**. Khomeini's 1979 revolution built the first modern theocracy: a **Supreme Leader** (a cleric with veto power) + a **Guardian Council (12 clergy)** vetting all candidates/laws, *above* an elected president & parliament (**Majlis**). The **1979 constitution** makes **Allah sovereign** and sharia the sole law. → *Theocracy — permanent tension between **theocratic authority** and **quasi-democratic** elements (shura/elections).*
- **Tanzania — Nyerere's one-party regime**. Julius Nyerere ("Africa's philosopher-king") justified a **one-party** state by claiming Africa lacked class divisions; his **ujamaa** "African socialism" ruined agriculture but achieved **near-universal literacy**; he **voluntarily resigned (1985)**. → *Civilian **one-party modernizing authoritarianism** — the "development vs democracy" trade-off.*



## Key terms

| Term                                | Meaning                                                                         |
|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Regime                              | Formal + informal institutions defining a type of government                    |
| Citizen / Subject                   | Member with rights + duties / person with duties (obedience) only               |
| Civil / Political / Social rights   | Marshall's three: freedom & fair treatment / participation / welfare & equality |
| Civil society                       | Organised nongovernmental, nonviolent activity beyond family/firm               |
| Social contract theory              | Legitimate govt = free individuals contracting to be governed                   |
| Liberal democracy                   | Democracy + liberalism; Dahl's 8 guarantees                                     |
| Social / Participatory democracy    | Adds social rights & economic control / adds direct participation               |
| Parliamentary sovereignty           | Parliament is supreme (UK)                                                      |
| Historical materialism              | Material/economic forces drive history (Marxism)                                |
| Dictatorship of the proletariat     | First communist stage: rule by the working class                                |
| Totalitarian state                  | Controls ~all of society, eliminates civil society                              |
| Vanguard party                      | Lenin: elite party leading the proletariat                                      |
| Corporatism                         | One state-controlled organisation per social sector                             |
| Modernizing authoritarianism        | Legitimacy from "development" by a modern elite                                 |
| Technocratic legitimacy             | Right to rule based on expertise                                                |
| Personalist regime / Neopatrimonial | One ruler dominates / power via personal patron–client loyalty                  |
| Electoral authoritarianism          | Hybrid: opposition + elections, but rigged                                      |
| Theocracy / Islamism                | Rule by religious authority / sharia as the basis of government                 |

## Exam pointers

- Nail the state / regime / government / citizen distinctions + Marshall's three rights (civil/political/social) — the framing for any answer.
- Reproduce the seven-type regime taxonomy (key idea + **who has power**) — and answer everything through the red thread: *how is power shared between citizens and the state?*
- Define liberal democracy via Dahl's 8 guarantees + the **three varieties** (liberal/social/participatory).
- Distinguish the **authoritarian types** with a case each: communism (Russia) • fascism (Germany) • modernizing (Brazil/Tanzania) • personalist (Nigeria) • electoral authoritarian (Mexico) • theocracy (Iran).



- Use the **V-Dem ladder** (closed autocracy → electoral autocracy → electoral democracy → liberal democracy) and the **Interests/Beliefs/Structures** lens to discuss *regime change*.

---

## ★ Fun facts & memorable details

---

Sticky stats, dates & quotes from Lecture 3 (regimes).

### Quotable lines

- Mussolini: "*The State is all-embracing; outside of it no human or spiritual values can exist*" — and he openly embraced the label "**totalitarian**."
- Marx: communism is "*a spectre haunting Europe*" (*Communist Manifesto*, 1848); liberal rights = "*equal rights for unequal people*."
- Nyerere: "*When a village of a hundred people have sat and talked together until they agreed where a well should be dug, they have practised democracy*."
- Locke's core liberties = "**life, liberty and property**" → Jefferson's "**life, liberty and the pursuit of happiness**."

### Striking numbers

- ~**90%** of the world's constitutions — including authoritarian ones — mention "democracy."
- **Dahl** = **8** guarantees of liberal democracy.
- Deaths under **Stalin**: estimated **2–20 million**; USSR dissolved **Dec 1991** into **15** states.
- Hitler's Nazis won **37% (1932)** and he was **elected** chancellor — not a coup; ~**6 million** Jews killed.
- The **PRI** ruled **71 years**, winning **98% of local/congressional elections 1946–73** (and **98.7%** of the 1976 presidential vote).
- Iran's **Guardian Council** = **12 clergy**; Iran is nearly all **Shiite**, though Sunnis are ~**85%** of the world's Muslims.

### Memorable facts

- The US has had **46 administrations but one regime** (since 1789); **Nigeria has had 8 regimes**.
  - "**Kremlinology**" — analysts inferred Soviet power from who stood closest to the leader at parades.
  - **Abacha** (Nigeria) looted ~**\$3 billion** and hanged the poet **Ken Saro-Wiwa**.
  - Le Pen's **National Front** came **2nd in France's 2002 presidential election** — neofascism didn't die with 1945.
  - The **three jihads**: inner struggle (most important) → righting injustice in the *umma* → armed defence (least important) — the reverse of the popular Western image.
-